

EARLY CANNON

The gun was first developed in medieval China. With the invention of gunpowder, blacksmiths there attempted to create a tube strong enough to contain its explosions. In the early 14th century, craftsmen in China, and then in Europe, made cannon by casting them in bronze. Shortly afterward, blacksmiths began to build cannon by assembling them from strips of wrought iron. The strips, or staves, ran lengthwise, and heated iron bands were placed around them. On cooling, the bands shrank, binding the strips tightly to form the bore of the cannon, a little like wooden staves form a wooden barrel. Early cannon were mostly loaded at the muzzle, with gunpowder and balls carved from stone. A vent in the barrel of the cannon allowed the gunpowder to be ignited, usually with a smoldering match-cord.

► BOXTED BOMBARD

Date c.1450

Origin England

Length 7¼ft (2.4m)

Caliber 13in (230mm)

As with most types of early gun, bombards had a narrow powder chamber and a wider bore. This helped to concentrate the force of the exploding gunpowder and to focus it behind the center of the ball.



▲ FLEMISH BOMBARD

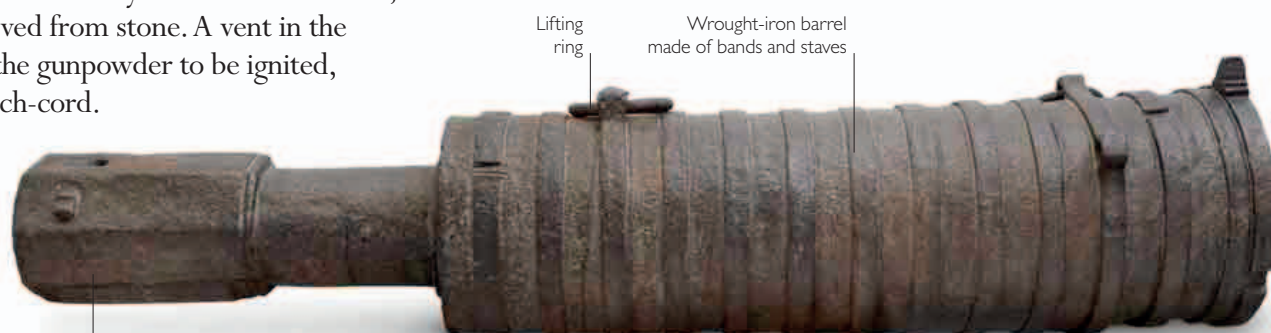
Date Early 15th century

Origin Flanders

Length Not known

Caliber Not known

In the 1400s, large siege guns were known as bombards. The stone balls they hurled were loaded through the muzzle after the gunpowder charge. Flanders, where this bombard was made, had a strong tradition of gunmaking, particularly during the reign of Charles the Bold (1433–77).



Powder chamber in breech



Towing eye